

In the The Snoring Elf Inn, a bustling tavern of Melvaunt, where the melodies of laughter and clinking tankards filled the air, Killy MacKilly, the giant gladiator from the Moonshae Isles, found himself enjoying a well-deserved tankard of ale. His broad, booming Moonshae accent lent a hearty charm to the surroundings, and his eyes, sharp with mischief, spotted a forlorn figure sitting alone with a heavy heart and nursing his ales.



Without uttering a word, Killy sidled up to the despondent soul, shooting a sideways glance that spoke volumes of camaraderie. And then, as if a ticklish sprite had possessed him, he starts chuckling, that grows to some guffaws, before he bursts into a loud, infectious laughter that echoes through the tavern like a wildfire.

The stranger looked up, startled at first, but in the face of the growing tidal wave of glee soon the corners of his mouth twitched. As if unable to swim against the torrent of jolliness, or not having

the strength or will to hold onto his pain, and before he knew it, his laughter joined the spirited gladiator.

Others in the tavern caught wind of the merry commotion and joined in the laughter, their worries momentarily forgotten in the enchanting spell woven by Killy MacKilly.

In the midst of the high spirits, a question from one of the drunken companions of the table is quietly asked and a broad grin stretches further. Killy was drunk enough that the opportunity to share a true tale from his youth was a great idea, when he was just a brawny lad with dreams of adventure.

"A was always a lang muckle laddie, even as a bairn." Killy began, his voice warm with nostalgia. "A was nae orc, but maist of the loun felt ma clowt somewhat. Sit down ye, ye asked and a ... Haud your wheesht! The bonnie lassie thare is bringing more for you ta drank. Sit down, or feel ma clout?!"

The nou ya asked to ken where my axe came frae, and ai'm learn ya."

"When ae was nae more than a lad, the tales of the Hot Gates had gone far and wide, and they came to my little corner of the Moonshae, as fast as the makker could sing. All the bairns were wild with it. Our families had fought the orcs, so we knew that fighting the hordes was a mighty, mighty feat. Everybody wanted to be Nikolai Steele. Ae used me maw's smithy to make me ain axe (so me maw was a smith, she learnt me as a bairn. Ye got a problem, wee man?) and so, as ae was saying, ae was Nikolai. Ae attacked those trees like Nikolai hewed through the orcs."

As Killy delved into his tale, the tavern-goers became more engrossed, if also more bleary-eyed, as their tankards refilled again and again as the night grew deeper.

"But it was Fearghal who was the braw, gallus one. He was the one who tied the fishnets together, he was the one who charmed all the maws, he was the one who said we had our own Hot Gates in the woods to the south. He was the one we followed. He was our Nikolai." Like a rapid stormfront, Killy's mood changed and he finished his tankard and yelled for another. "We stumbled upon a wandering band of orc raiders, and they laughed at us, thinkin' we were nothin' but wee lads playin' at bein' heroes," Killy continued, his eyes gleaming with baleful, fiery mischief. "But then, ae swung ma axe, and when the first orc fell, their laughter turned to terror!"

The audience remained rapt, their voices hushed as the tale unfolded, the ale slowly taking its hold.

"In the midst of a mighty fecht, Fearghal wis struck down tryin' to save one of the wee bairns," Killy's voice turned somber, instantly feeling the stabbing pang of loss just as if it happened again. But from under lowered brow, and fierce mien, Killy glared out at what no-one else saw. "But his sacrifice fueled ma rage, and ae cut a swathe through the orcs, defeatin' their afearsome leader." Looking at him, anyone paying attention might have thought Killy wasn't in a tavern anymore, nor drinking with friends. "And that, ma friends, is how the kenspeckle axe ae use in the Great Arena, the orc leader's ootstaundin axe, became mine."

The tale reached its poignant yet triumphant peak, and almost emotionally spent, Killy looked around the tavern, only to find his audience had surrendered to the embrace of slumber, their heads resting on tables and shoulders.

A rueful smile played on his lips and a rolling chuckle fell, as he observed his dozing companions, but then his eyes fell upon the buxom barwench, her gaze holding an unmistakable interest.



Killy's smile widened into a cheeky grin that stopped his chuckle, and he waggled his eyebrows at the barwench, his charm on full display.

"Ah, lass, the nicht is young, and there's still much to be explored," he said, his voice smooth as heated, honeyed mead.

The barwench chuckled, her eyes twinkling like stars on a clear night. "Indeed, Killy MacKilly, and I'm more than willin' to join ye on this adventure," she replied, her voice laced with playful delight.

And so, with the moon casting its gentle glow upon them, Killy MacKilly, the enormous human gladiator from the Moonshae Isles, embarked on a new tale - one of laughter and romance, of dreams and daring, as they ventured into the enchanting night together, weaving their own story in the magical realm of Faerun.